

BEFORE

In the 1880s, Jews known as Zionists began to emigrate to Palestine to avoid religious persecution in Europe. By 1897 they were demanding their own state, and in 1917 the British agreed to the foundation of a Jewish state in Palestine.



EARLY ZIONISTS

ZIONISM

Zionism became an organized political movement in 1897 when its founder, Theodor Herzl, convened the First Zionist Congress. The congress called for a Jewish state in Palestine.

SYKES–PICOT AGREEMENT

When the Ottoman Empire **◀ 246–47** collapsed during World War I **◀ 372–75**, France and Britain signed the 1916 Sykes–Picot agreement, dividing the Empire's Middle Eastern territories between them. France gained the mandate for Syria and Lebanon, and Britain was granted the mandate for Iraq and Palestine.

MANDATE An Ottoman or German territory that was handed to another country to run after World War I.

THE BALFOUR DECLARATION

The 1917 Balfour Declaration was a policy drawn up by the British government that accepted the need for a Jewish homeland in Palestine.

The Promised Land

According to the Bible, the land of Palestine was promised by God to the Jewish people. In 1948 the modern Jewish state of Israel was established in the region, causing fury among Palestinian Arabs and in the wider Arab world. It has proved one of the most contentious political acts of modern times.

The period of British rule in Palestine, which formally began in 1919 when the British Mandate (see BEFORE) was granted, was marked by controversy and violence. The majority Arab population strongly contested the Jewish settlers' claim on their country, and some Arabs resorted to aggressive attacks against Jews, their homes, and their businesses. The Jews, feeling that the British authorities were giving them insufficient protection, began to form local defense groups, known collectively as the Hagannah, to protect their communities. During the 1930s the Hagannah turned into a paramilitary organization, developing military training programs and sourcing arms from Europe.

The British withdraw

Guerrilla violence between Arab groups and the Hagannah became increasingly difficult for the British to police, so in 1939 they called together Arab and Jewish delegations to the St. James Conference, also known as the Round Table Conference, to find a solution to the ongoing tensions.

UN Partition plan

Under the plan the Jews would receive the northern coastal plain, eastern Galilee, and the Negev. The Arabs would get a section of desert bordering Egypt (the Gaza Strip), the Samarian and Judean highlands, and the southern coast.

KEY

- Proposed Arab state
- Proposed Jewish state
- Proposed international zone
- Border of British mandate 1923



Jewish refugee

Like many of the Jews who emigrated to Israel in the 1950s, this Yemeni girl stayed at the Shaar reception center in Haifa when she first arrived in the Jewish state.

No agreement was reached at the conference, so the British formed their own policy, which was stated in the McDonald White Paper of 1939. In it the British made concessions to the Arabs on a wide range of issues, the most important of which was a restriction on the free settlement in Palestine of Jewish refugees. This seemed like a death sentence for those Jews trying to flee Nazi Europe

(see pp.400–01) to Palestine.

Supporters of the Arab and Jewish sides held international conferences during 1946, but the year ended without any workable solutions to the problem. Caught between Arab and Jewish demands, a cash-strapped British government declared its mandate in Palestine “unworkable” in February 1947 and referred the matter to the United Nations. The UN proposed a partition plan, which allocated about 44 percent of the area for an

Arab state and 56 percent for a Jewish state, with Jerusalem under international administration. On November 29, 1947 the UN General Assembly voted 33 to 13, with 10 abstentions, in favor of the Partition Plan. The Jews agreed with their decision but the Arabs did not, arguing that the plan ignored the rights of the majority of people living in Palestine.

“In Israel, in order to be a **realist** you must believe in **miracles**.”

DAVID BEN-GURION, OLORA MANIFESTO, 1948



Wreck of Altalena

In June 1948 crowds gathered on the Tel Aviv beachfront to see the wreckage of the burnt-out Altalena. It had sailed from France to Israel carrying arms for the Irgun (a splinter group of the Hagannah) and about 900 immigrants. Ben-Gurion refused to let it land in respect of a truce with the Arabs, and ordered warning shots to be fired. One hit the vessel and it burned.

